

Instructor Guide — Lesson 7: Proposals, Communication, and Delivery

Metadata

Field	Detail
Path	Digital Independence Path → Course 17: Skills That Pay → Lesson 7
Age range	15–18
Format	Live, instructor-led (video call)
Duration	60 minutes
Tools used	Google Docs, Canva, Notion, Email (any provider), Spreadsheets (Google Sheets)
Prerequisites	L3–4 (student has a priced service package), L5 (finding first opportunities safely), L6 (marketplace age models)
Leads into	L8: full Client Simulation (student runs an entire mock client interaction start to finish)

Overview

By this point every student has a service package and a price. This lesson turns "I have something to sell" into "I know how to ask for the job professionally." Students learn to write a structured proposal, communicate with a client in a tone that is clear and warm rather than stiff or overly casual, and close out work with a simple, professional handoff. This is the last skill-building lesson before Lesson 8, where students will be evaluated running the whole client interaction themselves — so this lesson should leave them with a reusable proposal they could genuinely send.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to: 1. Write a proposal using a five-part structure: Understanding of Need, Approach, What's Included, Price, Timeline. 2. Apply professional communication norms — response time, tone, how to ask clarifying questions, how to say no or negotiate scope. 3. Execute a simple delivery/handoff process for finished work.

Prep (Before Class)

- Have a copy of the "Worksheet.md" proposal template open and ready to share-screen.

- Prepare the fictional client ask you'll use for the live demo (see Talking Points below; a sample is provided — customize if you want a fresh one).
- Open a blank Google Doc to write the demo proposal live, in front of students — do not pre-write it.
- Have the "client email etiquette" checklist ready to paste into the class chat or a shared Notion page.
- Know each student's service package from L3–4 (skim their worksheets beforehand) so you can tailor the individual proposal-drafting activity to something real for them.

Teaching Sequence

Time	Segment
0–5 min	Welcome, quick recap of L5–6, frame today's goal
5–20 min	Direct teaching: the proposal structure (5 parts)
20–30 min	Direct teaching: professional communication norms
30–42 min	Live demo: instructor writes a full proposal from a fictional client ask
42–52 min	Student activity: each student drafts their own proposal for a sample ask
52–58 min	Discussion questions + misconception check
58–60 min	Lesson close, preview Lesson 8

0–5 min: Welcome & Frame

Recap in one sentence each: "In L3–4 you priced a service. In L5 you learned how to find opportunities without getting scammed. In L6 you learned what marketplaces will and won't let you do at your age. Today you learn what to actually say to a client to get hired — and how to act once you're hired."

Ask: "Has anyone here already messaged a potential client — a neighbor, a family friend, a small business — about doing work for them? What did you say?" Use a real answer if you get one; it makes the lesson concrete immediately.

5–20 min: The Proposal Structure

Teach that a proposal is not an ad and not a contract — it's a short, specific answer to "why you, doing what, for how much, by when." Write the five parts on screen (or in the shared doc) as you go:

1. Understanding of Need — Restate what the client asked for, in your own words, in 1–2 sentences. This proves you listened and lets the client correct you early if you misunderstood.

Talking point: "This is the part almost everyone skips, and it's the part that makes clients trust you. If you jump straight to price, it reads like you copy-pasted the same message to twenty people."

2. My Approach — 2–3 sentences on how you'll do the work — not a full technical breakdown, just enough to show you have a plan. E.g., "I'll build the layout in Canva using your logo colors, then send two draft options for you to choose between before finalizing."

3. What's Included — A short bullet list of exact deliverables. This is the anti-conflict tool of the whole lesson: vague scope is where almost every freelance dispute starts. If it's not on this list, it's not included.

4. Price — One number (or a simple range if the scope is still fuzzy), stated plainly. No apologizing for the price, no burying it in a paragraph.

5. Timeline — A specific date or "X business days from when we confirm." Never "soon" or "whenever I get to it."

Optional 6th line some proposals include: **Next Steps** — what happens if the client says yes (e.g., "Reply to confirm and I'll send an invoice / get started Monday").

20–30 min: Professional Communication Norms

Frame this as: "The proposal gets you the job. How you communicate after that is what gets you the *next* job."

Tone. Teach the target: clear, warm, concise. Show contrast examples on screen: - Too stiff: "Per your request, please find enclosed my proposed terms of engagement." - Too casual: "heyyy so basically i can do this np just venmo me whenever lol" - Right tone: "Hi Alex — happy to help with this! Here's how I'd approach it, along with pricing and timeline below."

Response time expectations. Teach that professionalism is about *predictability*, not speed. A student who says "I check messages evenings after school and will reply within 24 hours" and sticks to it looks more professional than one who sometimes replies in 5 minutes and sometimes disappears for four days. Have students say out loud what their own realistic response window is, given school.

Setting expectations early. Teach the habit of naming constraints upfront: "Just so you know, I'm in school during the day, so I typically reply evenings and weekends" — said once, near the start, prevents most friction later.

Asking clarifying questions. Teach the format: acknowledge + specific question. "Thanks for reaching out! Quick question before I put together a proposal — do you want the logo redesigned too, or just the flyer?" Contrast with a bad version that asks five vague questions at once ("what do you want it to look like? what's your budget? when do you need it? etc.") — that reads as not having done any thinking yet.

Saying no or negotiating scope politely. Teach a simple three-part script: (1) thank them, (2) state the boundary plainly, (3) offer an alternative if one exists. - "Thanks for thinking of me for this! A full website redesign is outside what I offer right now — I mainly do social media graphics. I'd be happy to help with the graphics piece if that's useful." - For scope creep after work has started: "Happy to add the extra revisions — since that's beyond what we originally scoped, it'd be an additional \$10 and one extra day. Want me to go ahead?"

30–42 min: Live Demo — Instructor Writes a Proposal

Use this fictional client ask (read it aloud, paste it in chat):

"Hi! I run a small dog-walking business in my neighborhood and I need a flyer to hand out and post online. Nothing fancy, just something that looks nice. How much would that be?"

Live-write the proposal in the shared Google Doc, narrating each decision:

Hi [Client name],

Thanks for reaching out! Here's what I understand and how I'd approach it:

Understanding of Need: You'd like a flyer for your dog-walking business that works both as a printed handout and as a social media post.

My Approach: I'll design one flyer in Canva using a friendly, readable layout, then send you two color/style variations to choose from before finalizing.

What's Included:

- One flyer design, sized for both print (8.5x11") and Instagram post
- Two style options to choose between
- Up to 2 rounds of revisions
- Final files in PDF (for printing) and PNG (for posting online)

Price: \$25

Timeline: Draft options within 3 days of you confirming; final files within 2 days after you pick a style.

Next Steps: Just reply "yes" and let me know your business name, phone number, and any colors you'd like, and I'll get started!

Thanks,
[Student name]

While writing, deliberately narrate a mistake and fix it — e.g., first write "I'll make it look really professional and amazing and you'll love it!" then stop and say: "Wait — that's overselling. Let me just say what I'll actually do," and revise to the approach line above. This models self-editing, which is the real skill.

42–52 min: Student Activity

Give each student (or breakout pairs) a short fictional client ask — either a generic one below or one tailored to their own L3–4 service package — and have them draft their own five-part proposal in a Google Doc in 8–9 minutes.

Generic sample asks to assign: - "I need someone to make a simple logo for my lemonade stand." - "Can you help me organize my class notes into a clean study guide template?" - "I want a short intro/outro animation for my YouTube gaming videos."

Circulate (or use breakout rooms) and check for: missing price, vague "What's Included," no timeline, or tone that oversells.

52–58 min: Discussion & Misconceptions

Ask 2–3 students to read their proposal's "What's Included" and "Price" lines aloud. Then run the misconception check (below).

58–60 min: Lesson Close

"You now have a real proposal template and you know how to sound professional in messages back and forth. In Lesson 8, you're going to run the whole thing yourself — a simulated client will message you, you'll write the proposal, negotiate a bit, deliver the (mock) work, and hand it off — all the way through. Today's proposal format and the delivery checklist are exactly what you'll use, so keep your worksheet handy."

Common Misconceptions to Address

- **"A proposal should oversell to win the job."** Correct this directly: overselling ("this will be amazing, best ever!") creates a gap between promise and delivery, which is what damages trust and repeat business. A specific, honest "What's Included" list wins more consistently than hype, because it shows the client exactly what they're getting.
- **"Fast responses always matter more than clear, complete ones."** A one-line reply sent in two minutes that doesn't actually answer the client's question creates more back-and-forth than a clear, complete reply sent in two hours. Teach: predictable and complete beats merely fast.
- **"If the client doesn't push back on price, I should have charged more."** Not the focus of this lesson, but worth a one-line acknowledgment if it comes up — pricing was covered in L3–4; today is about the ask itself.
- **"Saying no to a client ruins the relationship."** Reinforce the three-part polite-no script — clients generally respect a clear, kind boundary more than a vague yes they later have to walk back.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

Difficulty	What you'll see	Troubleshooting move
Proposal turns into a sales pitch	Lots of adjectives ("amazing," "incredible"), no concrete list	Ask: "If I only read your 'What's Included' line, would I know exactly what I'm getting?" Have them replace adjectives with nouns/verbs.
No timeline or a vague one ("soon," "whenever")	Timeline line is blank or filler	Ask: "If the client asks 'by when,' what would you actually text back?" Convert that answer into the timeline line.
Price feels awkward to state plainly	Student buries price in a sentence, adds "sorry" or multiple qualifiers	Have them say the price out loud first, then write down exactly what they said.
Tone too casual (texting register) or too stiff (copied corporate phrasing)	Slang/emoji-heavy or "Dear Sir/Madam, per my previous correspondence"	Use the three-example contrast from the lesson; have them read their line aloud — does it sound like a real, friendly, competent teenager?
Freezes on "what if the client asks for more than I offer"	Doesn't attempt the negotiate/say-no section	Walk through the three-part script live with their exact scenario.

How to Review Student Work

Check each student's drafted proposal for: 1. All five parts present and each is one to a few sentences (not paragraphs). 2. "What's Included" is a specific bullet list, not a vague description. 3. Price is stated as a plain

number. 4. Timeline is a specific date or day-count, not "soon." 5. Tone reads as clear, warm, and concise — flag anything that oversells or that reads stiff/corporate.

Give feedback as one specific strength + one specific edit, e.g., "Your 'What's Included' list is excellent and specific — now give me an actual timeline instead of 'quickly.'"

Lesson Close / Bridge to Lesson 8

Remind students to save their proposal draft and worksheet — Lesson 8's Client Simulation will have them use this exact proposal structure and the delivery/handoff checklist in a live, timed, end-to-end exercise with a simulated client.